For Eli

By Andrea Gibson

INTRODUCTION

I grew tired of being told I didn't support the troops just because I wanted to bring them home to their families, and out of a senseless war. I understand there cannot be peace at all times, and the Iraq/Afghanistan was the correct conflict to become involved in, but my heart broke every time I heard, read, saw the names and faces of the fallen.

According to the Watson Institute, as of the beginning of 2015 . . . the number of US soldiers that died fighting the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan surpassed 6,800. And it was estimated that over 100,000 troops had been seriously wounded. In 2005, President Bush justified the loss of life by saying: "My decision to remove Saddam Hussein was the right decision. Saddam was a threat and the American people, and the world, is better off because he is no longer in power."

Saddam Hussein was captured, convicted and executed on December 30, 2006. But American troops were left stationed overseas until 2020, fighting a battle for democracy that many believed was not our battle.

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(Pg 17-20) Eli came back from Iraq

and tattooed a teddy bear onto the inside of his wrist

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above that a medic with an IV bag

above that an angel

but Eli says the teddy bear won't live

and I know I don't know but I say, "I know"

'cause Eli's only twenty-four and I've never seen eyes

further away from childhood than his

eyes old with a wisdom

he knows I'd rather not have

Eli's mother traces a teddy bear onto the inside of my arm

and says, "not all casualties come home in body bags"

and I swear

I'd spend the rest of my life writing nothing

but the word light at the end of this tunnel

if I could find the tunnel

I'd write nothing but white flags

Somebody pray for the soldiers

Somebody pray for what's lost

Somebody pray for the mailbox

that holds the official letters

to the mothers,

fathers,

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sisters,
and little brothers
of Michael 19. . . Steven 21. . . John 33
how ironic that their deaths sound like bible verses

the hearse is parked in the halls of the high school
recruiting black, brown and poor
while anti-war activists
outside walter reed army hospital scream
100, 000 slain
as an amputee on the third floor
breathes forget-me-nots onto the window pain

But how can we forget what we never knew
our sky is so perfectly blue it's repulsive
Somebody tell me where God lives
'cause if God is truth Ggod doesn't live here
our lies have seared the sun too hot to live by
there are ghosts of kids who are still alive
touting M16s with trembling hands
while we dream ourselves stars on Survivor
another missile sets fire to the face in the locket

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of a mother whose son needed money for college
and she swears she can feel his photograph burn
how many wars will it take us to learn
that only the dead return
the rest remain forever caught between worlds of
shrapnel shatters body of three year old girl to
welcome to McDonalds can I take your order?

The mortar of sanity crumbling
stumbling back home to a home that will never be home
again
Eli doesn't know if he can ever write a poem again

One third of the homeless men in this country are veterans
and we have the nerve to Support Our Troops
with pretty yellow ribbons
while giving nothing but dirty looks to their outstretched
hands

Tell me what land of the free
sets free its eighteen-year-old kids into greedy war zones
hones them like missiles
then returns their bones in the middle of the night

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so no one can see
each death swept beneath the carpet and hidden like dirt
each life a promise we never kept

Jeff Lucey came back from Iraq
and hung himself in his parents basement with a garden
hose
the night before he died he spent forty five minutes on his
father's lap
rocking like a baby
rocking like daddy, save me
and don't think for a minute he too isn't collateral damage
in the mansions of washington they are watching them
burn
and hoarding the water
no senators' sons are being sent out to slaughter
no presidents' daughters are licking ashes from their lips
or dreaming up ropes to wrap around their necks
in case they ever make it home alive

our eyes are closed
America

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there are souls in
the boots of the soldiers
America
[to hell with] your yellow ribbon
you wanna support our troops
bring them home
and hold them tight when they get here

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
Book: Pole Dancing to Gospel Hymns, Pgs 17-20
ISBN: 978-0981521305
Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
Date (Month/Year): June 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2019 National Qualifier – MS
CO State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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